

the proper documents. Wait for your application to be approved. Wait for your Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) card and other assistance to come in the mail.

Modonna is turned down because she didn't arrive early enough and is berated by a worker there for doing so. She's told to come back tomorrow, which is something these applicants don't have the time or resources to do. Modonna gave up that day, defeated. In Watkins-Hayes's research, the main reason people don't get welfare or stop receiving welfare is because of the "administrative hassle."

"These meetings, the paperwork, the scrutiny, the surveillance, it's just like, enough of this," Watkins-Hayes said. It's that way on purpose. "According to politicians, it's not supposed to be a fun and easy process, because they want to discourage usage. So they want all that paperwork, and they want it to be time consuming and they want it to feel like you're being highly scrutinized."

I'm a weenie. I won't go back to a grocery store if I've had an awkward encounter with a cashier, so the humiliation and frustration of Modonna's experience is horrible. A page later in the book, Edin and Schaefer quote another woman, Susan Brown, who says, "I just don't want to get rejected again." They wrote that she cries "uncontrollably" every time she gets turned down by a potential employer or government agency. Her heart can't take much more rejection. I don't blame her.



TAKEAWAYS

- ° The structures we have collectively created and live in are not working for the vast majority of us, but we can also collectively build a different system.
- ° If we're all so "bad with money," maybe the problem isn't us. Maybe it's the confusing and inaccessible ways how money and power are organized. Maybe it's the dark history integral to our country's financial system. Probably it's both.